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# New Bill Targets Crime in Disaster Zones – Here's What You Need to Know

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Lawmakers Push for Tougher Penalties To Protect Vulnerable Communities

California lawmakers have introduced a bipartisan bill aimed at cracking down on looting and impersonation of emergency personnel during wildfires and other natural disasters. The bill was announced at a press conference at the Los Angeles Hall of Justice.

Assembly Bill 469 (AB 469), introduced by Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), Jacqui Irwin (D-Thousand Oaks), and Blanca Pacheco (D-Downey), seeks to strengthen penalties for looting and fraudulent impersonation, close legal loopholes, and provide law enforcement with additional tools to protect communities in disaster zones. The legislation follows recent incidents in mandatory evacuation areas affected by the Palisades and Eaton fires, where looters and individuals posing as first responders have been arrested.

"Individuals who put our firefighters at risk and prey on communities when they are at their most vulnerable must be held accountable," Gabriel said in a statement. "This legislation will provide law enforcement with better tools to crack down on looting and impersonation and encourage criminals to think twice before engaging in such egregious conduct."

The bill has received broad support from law enforcement and fire officials, including the California Professional Firefighters, the California District Attorneys Association, the California Police Chiefs Association, Los Angeles County Sheriff Robert G. Luna, Los Angeles County District Attorney Nathan J. Hochman, Ventura County District Attorney Eric Nasarenko, and Los Angeles County Supervisor Kathryn Barger.

Los Angeles County District Attorney Hochman noted the urgency of the bill, stating that "there is zero tolerance for those seeking to exploit disasters through looting, arson, price gouging, and impersonation of first responders." He pledged to prosecute offenders to the fullest extent and called for making looting a felony.

If passed, the bill would:

The legislation responds to a growing number of looting cases following recent Southern California wildfires. Law enforcement reported multiple arrests of individuals attempting to steal from evacuated homes. In one case, two people from Oregon were arrested for impersonating firefighters in the Palisades Fire evacuation zone.

Assemblymember Jacqui Irwin emphasized the fear and confusion residents face during evacuations, stating that "as we rebuild communities devastated by wildfires, this legislation will help ensure safety and security within evacuation zones."

Pacheco added that "no one should have to choose between following evacuation orders and protecting their property. This bill sends a clear message: criminals will not be allowed to exploit Californians at their most vulnerable moments."

If approved by the Legislature and signed into law, AB 469 would provide law enforcement with stronger tools to deter and prosecute criminal activity in evacuation areas, reinforcing California's commitment to safeguarding communities during and after natural disasters.

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